

after my 10-year anniversary with the company, I received a letter from the chairman. He congratulated me on my decade with the company and looked forward to even more success for me in the coming years.

Six weeks later I was laid off.

The Missing Million

I took stock of the situation and decided that, at the age of 36, I had enough. Newspapers term guys like me *The Missing Million*. We are the ones who, for whatever reason, leave their jobs and decide not to go back into the workforce. We retire. Everyone, and I mean *everyone* (with the notable exception of my cousin Mary Ann—bless her heart), thinks we are nuts.

They're right, of course!

For the longest time, I have been fascinated with technical analysis of stocks. In the early years, I considered the little squiggles to be nothing short of voodoo. Still, I was curious as to why the major brokerage houses were hiring technical analysts in droves. But I did not dare take my eye off the fundamentals simply because I did not know anything about the technicals.

Then I discovered *Technical Analysis of Stocks and Commodities* magazine. During my lunch hour, I would take the elevator down to the library and read back issues. Although I saw chart patterns in the stocks I bought, I never really attached much significance to them. As some of my selections went sour, I began to view chart patterns with more respect. The fundamentals always looked good, but the technicals were signaling a trend change just as I was about to pull the trigger. The stocks I bought either lost money outright or I sold them too soon and cut my profits short.

Perhaps this has happened to you. You do fundamental research on a stock and then buy it, only to watch it go nowhere for a year or more. Even worse, once you get in, the stock tumbles. Had you looked at the chart the answer was always there. Prices pierced a trend line, a head-and-shoulders top appeared out of nowhere, the relative strength index signaled an overbought situation. In short, any number of technical indicators were screaming that a buy now would cost you your shirt. But you never saw the signs.